

Establishing a Just, Learning Culture

CSD380: DevOps

Module 8: Inject Learning Into Daily Work

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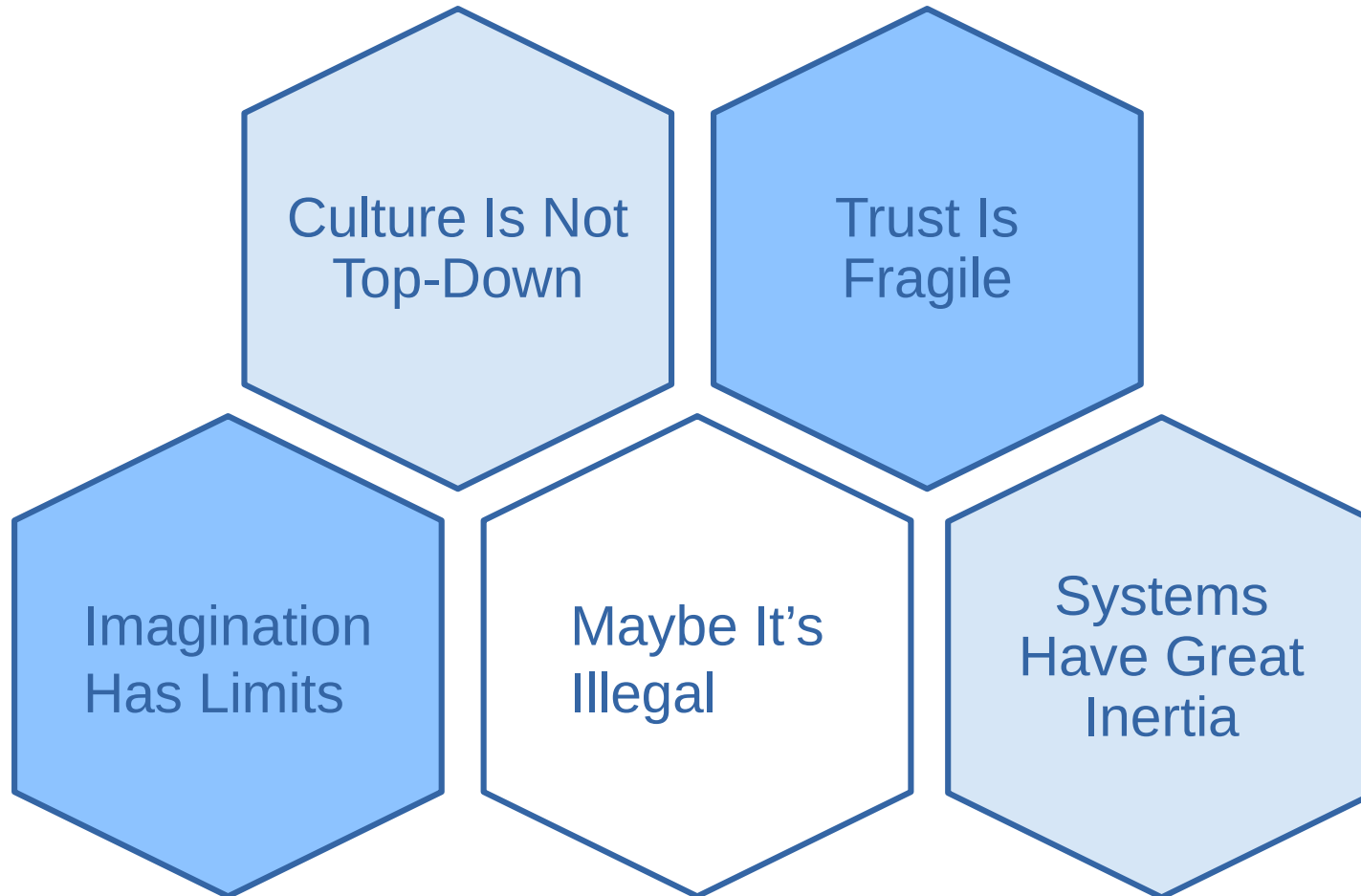
Elements of Just Culture

- At its heart, Just Culture is about feeling safe doing your job
- If you're worried about physical safety, organizational reprisals or reprimands, termination, political shame, etc., you cannot perform your job effectively
- These problems can create perverse incentives and tactical decision-making that produce worse outcomes for the organization

Elements of Just Culture

- An important key to solving this is a culture which focuses on learning and process improvement, and prioritizes it *over* the assignment of blame.
- From this mindset we get tools like blame-free post-mortems
- But I can't stress enough this extends all the way out to physical safety, and that's not theoretical - *this has been a problem in the software industry!*

Barriers to Just Culture



Culture is Not Top-Down

- Imagine I post a memo in the office saying, “In this company, we value cleanliness. It is an important part of our culture. Therefore, from now on, ALL employees shall wash their hands every time after going to the bathroom.”
- Everyone will not, in fact, wash their hands. It’s a fact.
- It’s more complicated than that to change culture. It’s about building coalitions and creating a groundswell of support.

Trust Is Fragile

- Imagine Fred has been faithfully submitting his code to reviews every week, and has taken a lot of painful advice.
- Fred does not like code reviews, but is trying to do the Right Thing.
- Fred has also watched his coworkers sneak past reviews and receive praise for their rapid dev schedule.
- Fred will soon emulate his coworkers or quit.

Trust Is Fragile

- Once disillusioned or betrayed, people like this are powerfully resistant to change, because they *do not believe their efforts will be met in good faith*.
- Please try to catch things before they get this bad.
 - But it is never too late to decide to be better.

Imagination Has Limits

- When we talk about changing culture, we're talking about performing roles we may not understand or imagine.
 - “Invisible” structural problems can motivate individual mistakes. It's much harder to blame the individual than to imagine the structure that's responsible.
 - People learn cultural mores as part of their job roles. Sometimes this is the only way we know how to be, and it can impede blame-free learning and process improvement.
 - E.G.: Punishment seen as a useful correction tool

Maybe It's Illegal

- Talking about a zero-judgement zone is all nice in theory, but
 - What if the GDPR was violated?
 - What if data was shared in violation of HIPAA?
 - What if ChatGPT was used by your legal firm in a court case?
 - What if any of the above was *intentional*?
- Sometimes a review can surface legal issues that legally or contractually **must** be addressed, possibly including immediate termination.

Systems Have Great Inertia

- Just like Trust is Fragile – people have long memories, but organizations do too.
- Often said about process improvement: “We tried that, and it didn’t work.” (they tried it once half-heartedly ten years ago)
- Organizations which are successful are averse to changing the formula, afraid of losing what made them successful.

Breaking free of this cycle requires coalition-building:

- **Being honest and open about problems**
- **Seeking out who is affected and understanding what their needs are**
- **Empowering management to enact structural change**
- **Working with ground-level employees to encourage buy-in and effect that change**

Thank You!

References

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